Lecture 28.02: Decision Tree Classifier & Recursive Splitting

📌 Topic Overview

How does a Decision Tree Classifier actually decide which feature to test first? In this lecture, we examine the classroom applicant dataset, the concept of **node purity**, and the recursive splitting process.

📊 The Classroom Loan Applicant Dataset

In the lecture, the instructor presents the following 6-sample dataset on the blackboard:

Credit Score	Employed	Loan Approved (Target)
Low	No	No
Low	Yes	No
Medium	Yes	Yes
High	Yes	Yes
Medium	No	No
High	No	Yes

Target Distribution at Root:

Total samples = 6:

- Yes = 3
- No = 3
- Notation: $[3y, 3n]$ (completely mixed / 50-50 uncertainty).

❓ The Two Fundamental Questions of Tree Building

To build a decision tree classifier, the algorithm must answer two core questions at every step:

1. **Feature selection for split**: Which feature (`Credit Score` or `Employed` ?) should be chosen at this node?
2. **Degree of purity of a split**: How do we measure whether a proposed split actually makes our subsets cleaner and more homogeneous?

🌳 Splitting on Feature 1: `Credit Score`

Let us test splitting the root $[3y, 3n]$ by `Credit Score` (Low, Medium, High):

```
flowchart TD
Root["Root: Credit Score [3y, 3n]"] -->|"Low"| L1["Low: [0y, 2n] (Pure)"]
Root -->|"Medium"| L2["Medium: [1y, 1n] (Impure)"]
Root -->|"High"| L3["High: [2y, 0n] (Pure)"]
```

Observations:

- **Low branch**: Contains 2 samples, both are `No` $\rightarrow [0y, 2n]$. This is **100% Pure (Homogeneous)**! No further splitting needed; this becomes a Leaf Node predicting `No`.
- **High branch**: Contains 2 samples, both are `Yes` $\rightarrow [2y, 0n]$. This is **100% Pure (Homogeneous)**! This becomes a Leaf Node predicting `Yes`.
- **Medium branch**: Contains 2 samples, one `Yes` and one `No` $\rightarrow [1y, 1n]$. This is **Impure (Heterogeneous)**. We cannot make a confident prediction here!

🔄 Recursive Splitting: Handling the Impure Node

Since the `Medium` node is impure $[1y, 1n]$, we must split it further using the remaining unused feature: `Employed?`

```
flowchart TD
Med["Medium Credit Score [1y, 1n]"] -->|"Employed == Yes"| L_yes["[1y, 0n] -> Appr
Med -->|"Employed == No"| L_no["[0y, 1n] -> Rejected (No)"]
```

Now:

- If `Employed == Yes` $ \rightarrow [1y, 0n] ($Pure$ \rightarrow$ Approved).
- If `Employed == No` $ \rightarrow [0y, 1n] ($Pure$ \rightarrow$ Rejected).

Every single branch now terminates in a completely pure leaf!

💻 Python Implementation

```
import pandas as pd
from sklearn.tree import DecisionTreeClassifier, export_text

# Recreating the exact classroom dataset
data = {
'Credit_Score': [0, 0, 1, 2, 1, 2], # 0: Low, 1: Medium, 2: High
'Employed': [0, 1, 1, 1, 0, 0],     # 0: No, 1: Yes
'Loan_Approved': [0, 0, 1, 1, 0, 1] # 0: No, 1: Yes
}
df = pd.DataFrame(data)

X = df[['Credit_Score', 'Employed']]
y = df['Loan_Approved']

clf = DecisionTreeClassifier(criterion='entropy', random_state=42)
clf.fit(X, y)

print("Learned Decision Rules:")
print(export_text(clf, feature_names=['Credit_Score', 'Employed']))
```

🔑 Key Takeaways

1. A node is **pure (homogeneous)** when all its samples belong to the same class.
2. An **impure (heterogeneous)** node contains a mixture of classes and requires further splitting.
3. The decision tree repeats this splitting process recursively until all leaves are pure or a stopping condition is reached.